

Q.6b (15 marks): What were the main ideas proposed by Tylor in his influential work Primitive Culture

b) What were the main ideas proposed by Tylor in his influential work "Primitive Culture" (15 marks)

EB Tylor called "Father of Anthropology" in his seminal work "Primitive Culture" defined "Culture" - As that complex whole of knowledge, art, belief, ideas, material that man acquires by being part of society.

MAIN IDEAS OF TYLOR

- Evolution of culture
- Influences
- Religion
- Society and Evolution
- Methods

① Evolution of Culture:-

He applied POSITIVISTIC approaches and believed that culture evolved like a biological organism.

Influences (INFLUENCES) :- He stated that similar to Herbert Spencer theory and Darwin's (DARWIN'S) theory of evolution culture evolved

1.1) Culture evolved from Simple to Complex, homogenous to heterogeneous and from uniform to nonuniform forms.

1.2) He gave concept of "PSYCHIC UNITY of MANKIND". He said there is "general likeness that all humans share".

1.3) Concept of "Cultural Parallels": He said cultures from Africa to South East Asia used pottery in some time period or another. Thus drawing PARALLELS we know that all share psychic unity

1.4) "CULTURAL SURVIVALS": He said remnants of a culture remain and this shows cultural evolution.

[Eg] He showed example of coat tail and button behind jackets. He said clay pots are not in use but are used for show.

1.5) Culture evolved in stages:-

[Savagery] → [Barbarism] → [Civilisation]

as we move left:-

- decreasing "PRIMITIVENESS" (derogatory)
- Progress increases

2] Religion in Primitive Culture :-

He said ANIMISM is the most basic primitive culture. It is the belief in a "general doctrine of soul and general supernatural".

He said: animism - polytheism - monotheism
was evolution

Genesis of animism He said it was to explain the phenomenon of death, dreams and other unexplainable scenarios.

He called them IRRATIONAL and INCORRECT.

3] Methods :- He used travel monologues, magazines, secondary information to formulate the same.

CRITICISM AGAINST PRIMITIVE CULTURE

① Diffusionists - lack of attention to diffusion and countered PSYCHIC UNITY OF MAN

② Brantz Mead - speculative, pseudo and conjectural no attention to DIVERSITY

③ New Evolutionists - lack of empirical basis

Despite this TYLOR inspired many anthropologists and was one of first to establish it as a DISCIPLINE.

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